

Module 1: Foundations of Global Migration

Signature Learning Experience

Purpose

This reflective essay anchors the whole course: before studying data, law, or policy, students examine where their own ideas about migration came from. The essay asks students to trace the sources of their assumptions — family stories, media, politics, religion, personal encounters — and test them against the module's concepts and evidence.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Define key migration terms accurately in your own writing (UG 1)
- Distinguish migration types when describing real or remembered examples (UG 2)
- Explain global migration patterns that confirm or contradict your assumptions (UG 3)
- Reflect on personal assumptions and where they originated (UG 4)

Graduate extension

Graduate students add a theoretical layer: identify which migration framework (e.g., push–pull, aspiration/ability, world systems) their inherited narrative implicitly assumed, and critique that framework using at least three peer-reviewed sources (Grad 1–2).

Assignment steps

1. Before doing the readings, free-write for 20 minutes: What do I believe about who migrates, why, and whether it is good or bad? Where did each belief come from? Keep this un-edited draft.
2. Complete the module readings and lecture; note every point where the evidence surprised you or contradicted your free-write.
3. Choose 2–3 of your strongest initial assumptions and research each against course sources (de Haas, Carling, UN/IOM data).
4. Write the essay: describe the narrative you held, its sources, what the evidence says, and how your understanding has shifted (or been confirmed — honest confirmation is acceptable if evidenced).
5. Use at least five key terms from the module correctly (migrant, refugee, asylum seeker, IDP, forced/voluntary migration, involuntary immobility).
6. Close with one question about migration you now want the rest of the course to answer.

Deliverables & format

- Essay, 1,200–1,500 words (graduate: 2,000–2,500 with theory critique)
- Original free-write attached as an appendix (ungraded, required)
- Minimum 4 course sources cited (graduate: 7, at least 3 peer-reviewed)

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Accurate use of migration terminology 25%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: accurate use of migration terminology is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: accurate use of migration terminology is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: accurate use of migration terminology is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: accurate use of migration terminology is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Quality of evidence used to test assumptions 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: quality of evidence used to test assumptions is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: quality of evidence used to test assumptions is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: quality of evidence used to test assumptions is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: quality of evidence used to test assumptions is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Depth and honesty of reflection — genuine examination, not performance 30%	Reflection is genuinely self-examining: depth and honesty of reflection — genuine examination, not performance shows specific assumptions confronted with evidence, real change or evidenced confirmation, and questions that extend beyond the assignment.	Reflection is substantive: depth and honesty of reflection — genuine examination, not performance shows honest engagement with the student's own thinking, supported by course material, with occasional generality.	Reflection is surface-level: depth and honesty of reflection — genuine examination, not performance is attempted but stays safe or generic — conclusions asserted rather than examined, little connection to evidence.	Reflection is performative or missing: depth and honesty of reflection — genuine examination, not performance shows no genuine self-examination or contradicts the evidence presented.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Writing clarity and citation 15%	Communication is publication-ready: writing clarity and citation is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: writing clarity and citation is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: writing clarity and citation is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: writing clarity and citation is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.